opinion polls and scholarly arguments such as those mentioned point to the gulf between Japan's elected leaders and its population. As Soeya acknowledges, leaders from both major Japanese political parties, the Liberal Democrats and the Democratic Party (DPJ), have supported an expansionist role for Japan's diplomacy and security policies over the past decade. It was DPJ premier Yoshihiko Noda, for example, who publicly embraced revising the restrictions on collective self-defense, keeping alive a policy preference from the first Abe administration in 2006–7. Moreover, Noda made the decision to purchase the F-35 Joint Strike Fighter and to reorient Japan's security strategy to focus explicitly on defending the Senkakus and other southwestern islands. Though his policies have gone farther and are more controversial, Abe is no outlier among Japanese policy makers. Rather, he is pushing to a logical conclusion the modernization in Japan's security and foreign policies that began in earnest in 1998 with the first North Korean Taepodong ballistic missile launch over Japanese territory.

Perhaps the ultimate endpoint of Abe's attempts to broaden Japan's role in the world is the most symbolic: revision of the country's postwar constitution. Written over a matter of weeks by the American occupying force in 1946, the constitution was promulgated the following year, including its famous Article 9, forever renouncing "war as a sovereign right of the nation and the threat or use of force as means of settling international disputes." Despite the corollary abjuration of maintaining "land, sea, and air forces, as well as other war potential," the Japanese Self-Defense Forces have nonetheless developed into one of the world's most capable militaries, underscoring the incompatibility between the nation's fundamental political document and the reality required for self-defense.

Article 9 is perhaps the single most controversial political issue in postwar Japan, decried by conservatives, who question the double standard that seeks to limit Japan's sovereign right to maintain a military and act in its self-interest, and celebrated by liberals, who see it as the apotheosis of modern Japan's penance for the aggression and atrocities of the Pacific War era. While the article has done little to prevent Japan